

A Peek into Open Source Licences

Open source is the mantra of today's tech world. While it's being used in that personal computer sitting on your desk, it is also being used in the computing systems in NASA's International Space Station! But merely knowing how to use open source software is no longer enough. Open source enthusiasts should also be aware of the various open source licences used. This article briefly touches upon what open source is all about, and scratches the surface of a few popular licences.



It is better to begin with a thorough understanding of the definition of open source. The Open Source Initiative (OSI) has set down certain criteria for open source software. Any software that provides the source code does not automatically qualify as open source. It should satisfy the following criteria:

- It should be available for free distribution.
- The source code should be made available free of cost. Deliberate obfuscated code and intermediate forms of code like the pre-processor outputs are not allowed.
- The licence should allow others to build works derived from the main project, and the works derived from the main project should also be distributed under the same licence.
- The integrity of the author's source code.
- There should be no discrimination against person or a group. This clause ensures that the code is not restricted to within a firm, or discriminated based on groups like developers, designers, etc.
- There should be no discrimination against the field of application.

- Regarding the distribution of the licence: The rights attached to the program must apply to all whom the program is redistributed to without the need to execute an additional licence by those parties.
- The licence must not restrict other software from being used in the same system.
- The software must be technology neutral.

Once the software satisfies all the above criteria it is called open source. Now, let us explore a few open source licences that are popular. But before that, let us discuss *copyleft* licences. The most popular belief regarding copyleft is that it is the opposite of copyright laws. But that is not the exact definition. Copyleft is the practice of using copyright law to offer the right to distribute copies and modified versions of a work while requiring that the same rights be preserved in modified versions of the work. In other words, copyleft is a general method for making a program (or other work) free (*libre*), and requiring all modified and extended versions of the program to be free as well.